

Eastern Airlines Flight 401

Flight model: Lockheed Tristar
Date: December 29, 1972

From: New York, US
To: Miami, Florida

Problem

The plane took off and covered the required distance with no sign of any fault. The plane near the destination airport while preparing for landing the pilots noticed that the indication lights for the nose landing gears were not lit. The pilots devoted their entire focus on it. There were 2 active crew and 2 were on standby for the flights. Suspecting one of the 2 possibilities of either a led fault or actual landing gear failed to deploy. The one of the standby crew was able to check the status of the nose gear through the **hell hole** located in the cockpit. The pilots and requested a for a go around. The passengers through the windows notices that the plane was in a constant descend. By the time the pilots had noticed the plane had little room for correction and had crashed into a farmland. It is worth noting that when the plane attitude reaches the ground level the radar in the ATC reads CST or Costal. There were few survivors from the crash. When the plane had crashed there was

Investigation

In the investigation, it was found that the crash site was very large which means that the plane should have been at a nose up position with a slow but gradual descend when it had crashed. When check it cockpit settings that the pilots had made. It was found that the plane was set to auto pilot as a part of the go around procedure as instructed by the ATC controller. All the instruments were tested and the instruments along with the engine was in a very good condition during the flight, many part of the plane in fact after the crash were given to other plane to used used for its repairs. The ATC had seen that the plane was losing altitude but as per the FAA's regulation it was not the ATC responsibility to inform the pilots regarding the same. The planes internal low altitude alarm is seen to have turned on when it reaches a certain threshold. This observation was made using the flight VCR. But the pilots were distracted by the landing gear problem because of which the alarm failed to capture the pilots attention. The investigators finally find that the pilots have a high trust on modern flight computer systems. Which the investigators believe was not a good sign. One of the pilots had written a statement to the NTSB that the plane had few abnormalities. When the plane's control column was disturbed the Altitude control of the auto pilot was disengaged. The crash occurred in the mid of the night which made the pilots lose any visual clue of the descend. The manufacturer had not instructed the any crew during trained regarding this feature. The case was closed on the conclusion that the crash was due to pilots negligence. The nose landing gear indicator was in fact a led fault.

Changes that were brought after the incident

The report advises the ATC to inform the pilots when the altitude of the plane was too low. NASA later started its study on the human behavior to reduce any pilot's error and had developed the **CRM (Crew resource management)**. All the crew members of the flight were working on the same problem which had led to no pilots noticing the lose of altitude. The CRM also trains the pilots not to get influenced by the mood of the co-pilot.

Reference

1. The Fatal And Devastating Crash Of Flight 401 — FULL EPISODE — Mayday: Air Disaster
<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ABQaTJvvQy0>